

Why Most Men Will NEVER Reach 10% Body Fat

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Jul 14, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PLi8SqWQzds> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Brandon Carter breaks down the five specific reasons most men never reach 10% body fat — from flawed math and the "muscle tax" to biological resistance and daily friction — and offers concrete fixes for each.

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Reason 1: The Muscle Tax 0:00

- The core idea: bigger, more muscular guys have to burn off more total pounds of fat than smaller guys to reach the same body fat percentage
 - Body fat percentage is relative to total body mass — so the more mass you carry, the more fat those percentage points represent
- Example breakdown (all starting at 20% body fat, targeting 10%):

Person	Starting Weight	Fat to Lose
Lean 150 lb kid	150 lb	~16–17 lb of fat
Average 200 lb guy	200 lb	~22 lb of fat
Muscular 250 lb guy	250 lb	~20 lb of fat

- Analogy: think of it like a sale at an Apple Store
 - A \$2,000 iPad Pro and a \$1,000 iPhone are both 50% off
 - You save \$500 on the iPhone but \$1,000 on the iPad — same percentage, more absolute dollars
 - Same principle: two guys dropping the same percentage points of body fat will lose very different amounts of actual fat if one is bigger
- Practical implication: many bigger/more muscular guys genuinely don't know how much fat they have to cut, and underestimate the task
- **Free tool mentioned:** the "Ripped Road Map" (link in description)

- Enter height, weight, and goal; upload a photo
- AI scans the image and estimates current body fat %, total fat mass, and fat to lose
- Also outputs daily calorie and macro targets
- 100% free



Reason 2: Doing the Math Wrong 3:04

- Common mistake: people assume losing half their fat gets them to half the body fat percentage
 - Example: 150 lb person at 20% body fat = 30 lb of fat
 - Most people think: lose 15 lb → 10% body fat. This is wrong.
- Why it's wrong: 10% body fat means lean mass must make up **90% of total body weight**
 - If that person loses 15 lb, they have 15 lb of fat remaining
 - With 120 lb of lean mass and 15 lb of fat, total weight = 135 lb
 - Body fat % = $15 \div 135 = \sim 11.1\%$ — still over 10%
 - To actually hit 10%: lean mass (120 lb) must equal 90% of total weight → total weight must be ~ 133 lb → need to lose ~ 17 lb of fat, not 15
- The gap between "obvious guess" and "correct number" is small but meaningful, and compounds across a whole cut
- Recommendation: use the Ripped Road Map AI tool to do this math automatically



Reason 3: It Gets Harder the Leaner You Get 4:15

- Going from 20% → 15% body fat feels relatively easy; going from 15% → 10% is significantly harder
- Analogy 1 — walking a dog toward another dog
 - The closer the dog gets to what it wants (sniffing the other dog), the harder it pulls
 - More restraint required the closer you get to the goal
- Analogy 2 — needing to pee on the way home
 - The closer you get to the toilet, the more urgent it feels — it barely feels like you made it
- Biological reason: the human body evolved to store fat as a survival mechanism during famine
 - The body "wants" to hold onto fat and resists getting very lean
 - This resistance increases the leaner you become — it's not a personal failure, it's biology
- Men specifically store more fat in the lower abs last — common complaint of "I have the top two abs but not the lower ones" is expected, not a sign to quit
- **Critical tactical error:** people calculate their calorie target once at the start and never recalibrate
 - As you lose weight, your maintenance calories drop — the same deficit calculation stops working
 - Formula: body weight in pounds $\times 10$ = daily calorie target for fat loss
 - But you must recalculate this with your new body weight as you lose fat
 - Example: at 200 lb → 2,000 calories/day

- After losing 20 lb → now 180 lb → recalculate to 1,800 calories/day
- Check in and recalibrate every week

Reason 4: Losing Too Much Lean Mass 7:21

- To be at 10% body fat, lean mass must equal 90% of total body weight — so losing muscle makes the target a moving one and actively works against you
- Losing muscle also means you look "skinny fat" rather than shredded, even at low body weight
- **Fix: keep protein at 1 gram per pound of body weight (not lean body mass)**
 - Brandon emphasizes this is intentional — not a misquote of "per pound of lean body mass"
 - Even for a 300 lb person: 300 g of protein per day is "perfectly fine and perfectly safe"
 - Less than 1% of the global population is over 300 lb — extreme edge cases don't invalidate the rule for 99% of people
- Why protein matters for muscle retention:
 - Cutting calories without high protein = losing the muscle you worked for
 - With sufficient protein during a cut, you preserve muscle and look lean rather than soft
- Special case — beginners (first year of training):
 - The body is in an adaptation phase where it can build muscle and burn fat simultaneously
 - Keeping protein at 1 g/lb of body weight during this phase can produce muscle gain even in a deficit
 - This simultaneous effect typically only happens naturally in year one (or with PEDs after)
- **Bonus: the Thermic Effect of Food (TEF) — protein as a "cheat code"**
 - Your body burns calories digesting food, but the percentage varies by macronutrient:

Macronutrient	Calories burned in digestion
Fat	0–3%
Carbohydrates	5–10%
Protein	20–30%

- Example: eat 100 calories of protein → body burns 20–30 of those calories just digesting it → you only net 70–80 calories
 - Analogy: like a credit card that gives 20–30% cash back on every purchase
 - Compared to Brandon's Apple Card example (10% back at Apple Store), protein's TEF is 2–3× better
- Additional protein benefit: **satiety**
 - Protein takes more energy and time to digest → sits in your stomach longer → you feel fuller longer
 - Carbs and fat are easier to digest and easier to overconsume; carbohydrates are also addictive
- Sample math for a 300 lb person following the formula:
 - $300 \text{ lb} \times 10 = 3,000 \text{ calories/day}$

- $300 \text{ g protein} \times 4 \text{ cal/g} = 1,200 \text{ calories from protein}$
- Remaining 1,800 calories filled with fats and carbs as desired
- TEF erases roughly 240–360 of those protein calories automatically

Reason 5: The Friction Mistake 12:24

- Core concept: success often isn't about discipline or desire — it's about how much friction exists between you and the behavior you want

"Everything you want to do more of, you need to decrease the friction in between you and doing that task. Everything you want to do less of, you need to increase the friction."

- NBA three-point shooting analogy:
 - The best three-point shooters (e.g., Steph Curry) disproportionately come from wealthy households
 - Wealthy kids may have a hoop in the driveway or a private court — low friction to practice
 - Kids from the hood had to compete for limited public courts — high friction, less shooting practice
 - That's why hood kids develop dribbling (you only need a ball and a sidewalk) — low friction activity
 - It's not about who wants it more; it's about access and friction
- **Increasing friction for bad habits (example: ice cream)**
 - If ice cream is in the house, resisting it requires constant discipline
 - Solution: don't keep it in the house
 - Now getting ice cream requires: putting on a shirt, going outside, walking to a store — or ordering on Instacart and waiting for delivery
 - The craving doesn't disappear, but the friction makes acting on it unlikely
- **Decreasing friction for good habits (example: morning workout routine)**
 - Alarm placed across the bedroom → forces getting out of bed
 - Robe near the alarm → easy to grab
 - Slides right beneath the robe → easy to slip on
 - Pre-workout already mixed and waiting in the kitchen the night before
 - Workout clothes laid out right there
 - Result: the path from sleep to ready-to-train is fully paved with zero decisions required
- **Biggest friction mistake in fitness: not tracking calories and macros**
 - "You're not going to accidentally eat enough protein and you're just hoping you're accidentally eating in a caloric deficit"
 - Brandon has tracked calories and macros every day for over 20 years
- **Low-friction tracking solution: Claude AI with a custom prompt**
 - Use a specific Claude prompt (pinned at the top of a new conversation)
 - Works with ChatGPT too, but Claude has a unique capability: it syncs with Apple Health

- How to log a meal: tell Claude what you ate, take a photo of the food, or photograph the nutrition label
- Claude returns: macros and calories for that meal + a running daily total
- Because of Apple Health sync, Claude can also see calories burned and compute your real-time deficit
 - Example shown: Apple Health says 1,800 calories burned; eaten 1,000 calories → deficit of 700 calories, calculated automatically
- At end of day: Claude outputs total calories eaten, total macros, total calories burned, and final deficit
- Brandon tested it against a food scale — the food scale is more accurate, but Claude's estimates are close enough to be useful and require no equipment
- Brandon's example meals logged: 9 eggs + 150g blueberries; rotisserie chicken without skin (photographed and estimated without weighing)
- **To get the prompt:** DM Brandon on Instagram (@KingKeto) the word "tracking" and it will be sent to you (prompt is too long to post publicly)
- Final recap tool plug: the Ripped Road Map (free, link in description) — calculates your body fat %, fat to lose, and daily calorie/macro targets